

Rapid Contextual Design: Chapter 12 Storyboarding

One important point that I think the chapter brings up about storyboarding is that regardless of how little, it is still key to get data that the storyboard can be based off of. Even though this point is brief, the consequence that is described says a lot about why this is a necessary step. “We have seen teams spin their wheels and argue when they have no clear idea of how an activity is accomplished.” (p.232) – what this statement essentially says about the contextual designer role, is that although these teams have a lot of work and domain experience, being professionals in their own field doesn’t necessarily mean that they will be knowledgeable about how an activity should ‘theoretically’ be accomplished. That is why they can argue with each other about the different theories that they have, but without being able to take the perspective of an actual user, it’s impossible to have a clear idea. This is similar to the concept of how creators of writing are often the worst judge of their work, and the reason why it is absolutely essential that another person evaluate and proofread, because there is an inescapable filter in perceiving your own work where it’s even more difficult to find your own errors.

To me, the storyboard when described as “a set of hand-drawn pictures that let people think concretely about how the new work practice will work,” (p.232), is basically kind of like a temporally extended scenario. Because a scenario is more like a ‘snapshot’ of a real-life case relevant to the newly designed practice, a storyboard is like a snapshot that is a longer stretch in time, containing even more sophisticated contextual information about a situation. I think this is good in that it helps storyboarding to enable what is essentially more *meaningful* forms of investigating a user’s experience.

The caution tip on page 238 about not skipping the low-level vision and going directly to the storyboard frame. Low-level visioning for storyboarding, in other words having the team ground their discussion in drawings and look at alternatives when working out what the details of the storyboard should be, seems similar to the general rule of writing an *outline* for an essay before you write the actual essay itself, otherwise it may not be coherent and logically, as well as conceptually consistent all the way through.

Encouragement of emphasis on “driving out the details” of the work instead of worrying about making “neat or beautiful” storyboards is also a very good point. This is often something that I know is important to remind oneself of, even in issues such as research framing and development. Premature obsession with the perfectness of the final product will place huge restrictions on the development creative ideation and case-driven critical thinking that is required for fleshing out a conceptual product (such as storyboard or research proposal) to its true potential. It is also clear that in the storyboarding process there is a lot of cross-checking and reworking involved, so there is no need for a preoccupation with perfection that will stifle the idea-burgeoning process anyway.